

WOMEN OF MYSTERY

IN A PROFESSION DOMINATED BY MEN, WOMEN DETECTIVES ARE FINALLY MAKING A MARK. BUT THEIR EMERGENCE IS AN OMINOUS SIGN THAT ALL IS NOT WELL WITH THE MODERN INDIAN FAMILY.

■ By Damayanti Datta

Hours after his wife confronted him with reports of infidelity, he landed up at the lady detective's bureau. He yelled at the private eye, A.M. Malathy, for breaking up his marriage ("Why didn't you come up to me first? I'd have changed my ways"), gesticulated wildly ("She humiliated me in front of relatives") and thumped the table with his fist ("You won't get away with this"). That was this morning—the time that Malathy can't stop thinking about now. She had been trailing him for days. And it had taken guts and stamina to take his shots, billing and cooing with his lady-love, and tell the story to her client—the wife who insisted on knowing every intimate detail. Nursing a cup of coffee, she sighed: "It's the hazard of doing one's job well. But would he have dared to barge in like this if I were a man?"

All in a day's work, if you are a lady sleuth in India. Long a man's world, women are now taking their place alongside hardboiled gumshoes. In the big cities, they are not just working as private eyes, but heading and even setting up all-women outfits. Of the 60 detective agencies in Delhi, almost all have a sizeable number of women and six are run by women alone. If the Internet is any indication of the supply-demand curve, most agencies claim to be a "lady detective provider". Women check employee credentials for corporates, do under-cover operations, survey public opinion for political parties, carry out surveillance for fashion houses. But most of all, they excel in patrolling the dark alleys of that holy Indian institution—the family. "We enter homes, we talk to people without raising suspicion. And, often, we finish a job faster than men," says Malathy. In a society of fixed gender roles, that's a bold claim indeed.

The new demand for women sleuths is reflected in popular fiction, too. For the first time, and nearly 150 years after the first woman detective figured in Western literature, Indian women have started writing crime thrillers where the protagonist is a woman. Sixty, single, stylish and female, detective Lalli, a brain-

child of surgeon-author, Kalpana Swaminathan, is now solving crimes serially. There's also Sonia Samarth, who unravels cases using vedic astrology and has fetched up international ranking for her creator, Manjiri Prabhu. "Being a lady sleuth or women writing detective thrillers with women as the private eye, is as new a trend as it can get," affirms Swaminathan. "Both are asserting their own rights to appropriate that 'unsuitable' job of sleuthing for a woman."

Rajni Pandit, who heads Rajani Investigation Bureau in Mumbai, cracked her first case way back in 1989 as a student of Ruparel College. She caught one of her classmates, leading a dangerous double life. The same year, Malathy, an engineering student, stunned the detectives her family had appointed to solve a property case, with her sleuthing skills. She joined them, met the love of her life and went on to become the first woman to run a ladies' detective agency down South. Taralika Lahiri, who runs National Detectives and Corporate Consultants in Delhi's Panchsheel Park (and is the only woman member of the Association of Private Detectives and Investigators) walked into her profession that very year, by default: "I was working as a marketing executive with a security devices company. They